Recent Scholarship on Language and Gender

Tierra Parham

Michigan State University

College of Communication Arts and Sciences

LIN 225: Language and Gender

Professor Barnhardt

April 21, 2024

Language and gender are two completely different things that are known to have strong ties to one another. By definition, language is a system of spoken, signed, or written symbols that individuals use to express themselves, and gender refers to the performative actions labeled as masculine or feminine by society that are attached to women and men. Language is one of the ways in which gender is expressed. It reflects and creates the social world, holding a substantial amount of power.

Levinson (2014), "Language Evolution"

According to Stephen C. Levinson, a social scientist and research director in language diversity, language is extremely evolutionary (in spite of how language was traditionally treated as a fixed and romanticized method), because of the interplay between culture and biology. In fact, parallels with Darwin's theory of biological evolution. Similarly, both processes involve splitting over time generating variation and diversity. The study of language evolution pertains to the investigation of how languages develop from scratch and later change through the reproduction of language from the brain of one individual to another.

As discussed in class, it is quite evident that language evolves over time and results in a large amount of linguistic diversity. This article emphasizes that a role is played by both culture and biology in language evolution. Initially, I questioned how biology would have an importance here other than for its comparison using Darwin's evolution theory. However, after being given an example of a village adopting sign language being driven by hereditary deafness, and therefore leading to adaptations being made within the entire village clear up some confusion. Additionally, the discussion of language splitting over time and forming variants is key to evolution. It is inevitable for variants to form because humans are in no way identical, so

different ways of performing everyday actions like speaking should be expected. Then, following the formation of alternative ways of expressing the same points, they will either be dropped or taken in by others due to reasons such as convenience (i.e. language that is acquireable by children), resulting in something similar to a domino effect.

- C. Levinson, S. (2014). *Language evolution*. https://pure.mpg.de/rest/items/item_1835881/component/file_2470186/content

Leaper (2014), "Gender Similarities and Differences in Language"

Campbell Leaper, in his article examining gender-related variations in language, gives insight into societal norms, power dynamics, and biases. Language often exhibits gender bias. However, similarities between women and men typically outweigh the differences, and stereotypes pursue due to social reinforcement. According to Leaper, scientific research is key to dismantling myths about, and ultimately improving the understanding of gender; but sadly, information on the internet continues to retain gender stereotypes.

As I read this article, I found myself in strong agreement with the author, as it is very easy to recognize that language is used to create and maintain divisions by gender within society. Through stereotypes, gender categorizations with predicted characteristics of the members within that category are created, upholding them eagerly throughout the duration of life. When a situation occurs where an individual acts within the norms and expectations of their gender, the public takes notice, making comments such as "That's men for you", or any other comments along the same lines that highlight their prediction for that behavior from that gender. Yet, instances that contradict this view are not treated with the same regard. In other words, there is a

common, strong focus on the determined differences between genders. By means of this analysis, the societal inclination to show interest in any cases in which gender expectations are upheld but to overlook those in which they are not (because gender is subconsciously at the forefront of humanity's mind) is made apparent.

- Leaper, C. (2014). Gender similarities and differences in language. In *Oxford University Press eBooks*. https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780199838639.013.002

Bekzhanova (2023), "Uncovering Gender, Language, and Intersected Asymmetries in History Textbooks"

Zhazira Bekzhanova, a professor at Aktobe Regional Zhubanov University and sociolinguist, conducted research over gender inclusion and representation in Kazakhstani textbooks, which tends to have a deficit. Following analysis, it was revealed the language used in the textbooks showed strong gender bias, using masculine nouns as defaults (as Russian is a gendered language). This gives the impression that men are the standard and women come second to that. Furthermore, a support of gender roles was conveyed through the tendency to portray men with masculinity, power, and leadership; and women with femininity and vulnerability/weakness.

The enforcement of gender bias, roles, norms, and expectations is something that I see on a daily basis. Although this is conducted on individuals who speak in a gendered language, Russian, a language different to English which contains features of a natural gender language (one that has particular nouns and pronouns to refer to specific people of a specific sex and neutral pronouns for sexless objects); there are discernible similarities despite language.

Universally, men are understood to be superior over women; hence in some languages masculine pronouns are used to describe most things, men have better occupational positions, etc. So, for this study to reveal that the results of the textbooks analysis showed adequate depiction of men but underrepresentation of women; and that when they were represented, it was in susceptible ways, was not surprising. Gender norms atone for the common image of weak women and strong men, and without strong efforts to deconstruct this, it will continue to be taught to kids and later generations, therefore maintaining the toxicity.

- Bekzhanova, Z. (2023). Uncovering gender, language, and intersected asymmetries in history textbooks. In *The Steppe and beyond* (pp. 117–142). https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-99-8517-3_7

Ott (2016), "Tweet Like a Girl: A Corpus Analysis of Gendered Language in Social Media"

Social media equips the internet with an abundance of written language that is accessible for linguists to inferences. In particular, the social media platform *X*, formally known as *Twitter* and referred to as *Twitter* in the article, exemplifies perfectly how gender stereotypes are established, reinforced, and challenged through communication online. Through features such as syntactic structures, conversational topics, and vocabulary choice; differentiation between genders were concluded. Users that were women were said to employ feminine language patterns, while users that were men were said to masculine language patterns; falling in line with the societal expectations of gender norms. However, social media users do not constantly conform to those norms at all times.

For personal experience, gendered language patterns are very prominent in society. When I read a tweet on Twitter, I almost always feel that I know the gender of the individual behind it and reply with “Girl…” or a different tone for men. However, there is no way for me to be certain who is the actual author. Due to gender norms, society is taught that there is a normal, typical way of speaking for women and men. However, when the author is an individual who does not identify as a woman or a man, but uses language patterns of one of the two “main " genders; an inconsistency is created. What society thinks they know to be true for all is challenged. In the future, I believe there needs to be more of this, more individuals practicing nonconformity, because then more progress can be made towards disassembling gender norms and expectations and the acceptance of people who do fit under one category or the other.

Ott, M., Kouloumpis, Koppel, & LIWC. (2016). Tweet Like a Girl: A Corpus Analysis of Gendered Language in Social media. In Yale University, *Yale University*. https://ling.yale.edu/sites/default/files/files/Margaret%20Ott.pdf

Sulpizio, Fasoli, Maass, Paladino, Vespignani, Eyssel, Bentler (2015); “The Sound of Voice: Voice-Based Categorization of Speakers’ Sexual Orientation Within and Across Languages”

According to the authors of this academic article, the common way in which individuals categorize one another is not always true to reality. A voice can provide an individual with some information about a person, but solely using vocal characteristics to presume sexual orientation can lead to inaccurate perceptions. In addition to a possibly incorrect insight, stereotyping and even discrimination could be a result as well, considering that an inference about sexuality can

lead to the way someone decides to treat the individual. However, overall, the study suggests that categorizations based on voice are heavily based on the societal expectations of gender characteristics, rather than the valid identification of one's sexual orientation.

It is common for one to hear an individual speak, immediately identify any abnormalities in their tone, pitch, or vocabulary, and assign a presumed sexuality; unless that person's voice is in direct line with what is expected of their gender. From my experience, there was an influencer (singing) brother duo that I adored as a teenage girl. The older brother had the typical voice for a man and all of the girls loved him. The younger brother however, had a voice of a higher pitch and tone that is perceived by society as "gay", so under every video there would be at least one person leaving a comment assuming his sexuality. This brother eventually told everyone that he identified as straight, but it was not accepted by society since despite his claims of being heterosexual, he didn't fit the gender norm of a man; therefore, as a result, he was referred to as "closeted". This opened my eyes to the fact that what society says goes. To call back to the mention in the article that states that the standard way of classifying individuals based on sexual orientation is not in line with reality at all times, it is clear that there is no reality in which society can be wrong based on what they know to be true.

- Sulpizio, S., Fasoli, F., Maass, A., Paladino, M. P., Vespignani, F., Eyssel, F. A., & Bentler, D. (2015). The Sound of Voice: Voice-Based Categorization of Speakers' Sexual Orientation within and across Languages. *PloS One*, *10*(7), e0128882. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0128882

Ultimately, language and gender intersect to create more topics that are deep rooted in the gender expectations and norms of society. Then, due to those ideas, there is a common expectancy for them to be upheld and performed in everyday actions associated with the individual's gender; men act and speak masculinely while women act and speak femininely. In accordance with men holding more linguistic authority, gender roles are reflected and gender inequality is created. As shown, with time language continues to evolve. Thus, there can be hope for new ideas and processes surrounding language and gender to finally create a society in which individuals of all genders are able to feel represented and appreciated.